



backpage
Revisiting *The Last Princesses of Punjab*

GO TO » PAGE 8

INSIDE
Sā Biennale turns Ladakh's mountains into sites of art

GO TO » PAGE 4

LITERARY REVIEW
Douglas Stuart's new novel on Booker Prize longlist

GO TO » PAGE 2

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THE QUIET APPEAL OF SNAIL MAIL

As AI slop fills timelines, young Indians are rediscovering analogue experiences – the realness of a handwritten letter, of a hand-drawn postcard. The irony: they find it first on social media



Tomas Jauregui with Mythbridge's monthly snail mail envelopes.

Olimita Roy

On the last weekend of every month, Sowbharanika Lakshmipathy's dining table disappears beneath piles of paper. Handwritten letters wait to be folded, stickers are trimmed into neat sheets, bookmarks are stacked beside colouring pages, and rolls of washi tape lie scattered between envelopes waiting to be sealed.

Preparing each month's batch of mail is a process that unfolds over nearly two weeks. "I want every envelope to feel like it was put together for one person, not produced in bulk," says the Coimbatore-based founder of snail mail club Tamarai Tales. "By the time I'm done, it feels like I'm sending little pieces of myself."

Much of what goes into each package is written or designed by the 27-year-old IT professional. The rest is carefully curated by her from stationery makers. Each month revolves around a single idea. One package asks subscribers whether they feel they are falling behind in life. Another explores what it means to start over. Others centre on loneliness, friendship, self-worth and well-being.

Before sealing the last envelope, Lakshmipathy props up her phone against her ceramic coffee cup and records the process. Time-lapse videos

of handwritten notes and finished envelopes have become a familiar feature on her Instagram page, where many of her subscribers first discovered the club. It is an irony she readily acknowledges. "Social media helps people find me," she says. "But what I'm really hoping to give them is a reason to spend a little less time on it."

The envelopes make their way across India – to Bengaluru and Bhopal, Chennai and Chandigarh, Kochi and Kolkata, moving through post offices, sorting centres, mailbags and delivery vans before arriving at someone's doorstep. For most of human history, this would have seemed ordinary. In 2026, it feels almost radical.

Life beyond the digital

It is precisely this slowness that is drawing people in. As interactions become digital and social media fills up with AI slop, young people are rediscovering analogue experiences. Vinyl records are enjoying a resurgence; independent bookstores and pen-pal communities are flourishing; typewriter clubs, calligraphy workshops, scrapbooking circles and journalling communities are attracting thousands across the globe.

CONTINUED ON
» **PAGES 4-5**



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Anil Menon

I am John of John of Iain of Iain the Breatadair,” says John ‘Cal’ Macleod to an old Scottish woman who asks about his “sloinntireachd”, his lineage. When we meet Cal at the start of the novel, he’s a newly-minted graduate in textile weaving, unemployed, mostly drunk, and living a closeted life. He learns from his father, John Senior, that his maternal grandmother Ella has feet that are “as purple as calf liver”. She is unwell, and Cal decides to return home. John Senior is a scold of god, devoutly Protestant in the manner of those who feel permanently guilty. On the island of Harris, he is a well-regarded figure but also an object of pity. His wife Grace leaves him for his brother Uilleam, abandoning Cal and her mother Ella in the process. Instead of having the decency to move away, Grace chooses to hang about the island, have children with Uilleam, and most unforgivably, be happy. To put things in perspective, John Senior also lives a closeted life. This enclosure includes his childhood friend and lover, Innes MacInnes. Like Cal, John Senior too is a

weaver. But unlike his gentle offspring, John Senior is a taciturn, angry man who cannot forgive in others what he cannot forgive in himself. **Unmasking vulnerabilities** Douglas Stuart’s new novel *John of John* – longlisted for this year’s Booker Prize – is set in Scotland in the 90s, before mobile phones and the Internet. It’s a setting that the author has explored earlier, though in a more violent key, in his 2022 novel *Young Mungo*. There is an old-fashioned feel to the story. This is not due to the ‘90s setting alone. The closet issues aside, the Heimkehrroman (the story of a young person who returns to their hometown to figure things out) was quite popular in the West in the ‘80s and ‘90s. It

2026 BOOKER PRIZE-LONGLISTED

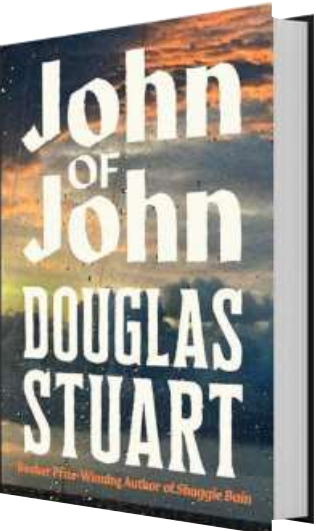
THE SINS OF FATHERS

Douglas Stuart’s homecoming novel unearths buried secrets and inherited shame

Race for the Booker begins

The longlist for this year’s Booker Prize, announced last week, features two past winners, a previous nominee and 10 first-time contenders. Former winners Douglas Stuart (2020) and Marlon James (2015) headline the 13-book list, which also includes Pulitzer Prize-winning author Elizabeth Strout and three debut novelists: American short story writer Kenan Orhan, English poet Rebecca Perry and Irish writer Djamel White. Describing the selection as wide-ranging, Booker Prize jury chair Mary Beard said the longlisted books are “set anywhere and everywhere: Ireland and Italy, Mexico and Massachusetts, Jamaica and the Hebrides, universities, private planes and pubs, past, present and future.” She added, “Every writer on our longlist brilliantly musters the power of words on the page to take the reader to new places, to see old places from new angles, to change minds.” A shortlist of six books will be announced on September 22, and the winner on November 9. The winning author will receive £50,000, while each of the shortlisted writers will be awarded £2,500.

played out in movies like *Beautiful Girls*, *Peggy Sue Got Married* and *Grosse Pointe Blank*, and in novels like Proulx’s *The Shipping News*, Swift’s *Waterland* and Russo’s *Empire Falls*. These stories often also include a local character, suitably attractive, whose main narrative role is to lead the protagonist to the right decision. *John of John* has such a character in Cal’s classmate, Isla Macdonald, a smart and ambitious young woman. The movie critic Roger Ebert was fond of saying that what mattered in art was how things were depicted, not what was depicted. Stuart’s novel is a great example of what good writing can do with well-worn narrative material. The dialogues, unusually lengthy and numerous for a literary novel, feel like conversations. The characterisation of the novel’s people makes me change my mind several times during the reading. This is especially true of John Senior: the more one learns about him, the more hesitant and nuanced one’s judgments about him tend to become. But even relatively minor characters are given a depth that makes one feel we would recognise them were we to meet them. This is because the novel’s interactions often uncloth the vulnerabilities. For instance, at one point, Cal makes the mistake of insulting ‘Beady’, the community’s moral watch-guard. Post-insult,



John of John
Douglas Stuart
Picador
₹899

there is a pause. “She smiled the smallest, tightest smile he had ever seen in his life.” And then the author tells us, through Cal, what that smile will entail. **Enjoyable read** The relationship between Ella and Cal similarly deepens as the novel steps through its 400 pages. Cal and his grandma have an easy relationship, near unconditional; one of its dimensions includes a mutual fondness for obscure and obscene words. The reader is the happy beneficiary. Lengthy, family-centric narratives tend towards soap-opera. This is evident in *John of John* as well. The last quarter-half is a relatively hurried wrapping up of plot threads, complete with dramatic drownings, grieving mothers, screams, out-of-wedlock babies and so on. The last dozen pages cram a revenge scene and a counter-revenge scene. There’s even a final chase, or rather, since this is a literary novel, a trot. Tragedy deferred sometimes turns into farce. Those who struggled with Stuart’s linguistic flex, *Shuggie Bain*, which won the 2020 Booker Prize, may approach *John of John* with some trepidation. They needn’t. This is an enjoyable and accessible novel, one that competently lives up to the expectations raised by its long and honourable *sloinntireachd*. **The reviewer is an author, most recently of The Coincidence Plot.**

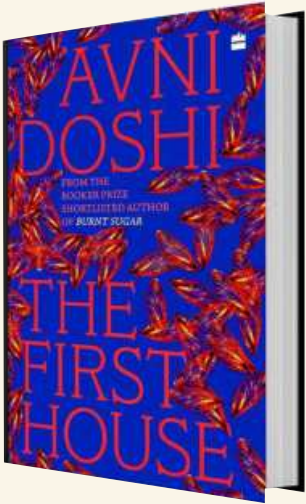
INTERVIEW

Metamorphosis and myth

Avni Doshi explores midlife reinvention and family politics in her new novel, *The First House*

Vidhya Anand

The Booker-shortlisted author of *Burnt Sugar* (2019) returns with a hypnotic second novel rich with mythological goddesses, headless women and astrological motifs. In *The First House* (published by HarperCollins), Avni Doshi, who is based in Dubai, lays bare the anatomy of intimate relationships and the upheaval of self-transformation that looks to deities and nature for meaning. Edited excerpts from an interview: **Question:** *How did the novel come about?* **Answer:** I had an idea about a family and a divorce, and there were various elements I had a sense of. I was living in this strange mid-life moment, seeing everyone around me in various forms of crisis, and what became apparent was that something shifts at mid-life. This one way in which we live, which is outwardly



focused, ticking all the boxes, doing everything your parents wanted you to do or doing everything society wanted you to do, suddenly no longer has any meaning. I wanted to write about this in a more dramatic form, which included this divorce and this relationship with the family. **Q:** *In the novel, there is this idea of the process of*

transformation being ugly, with cicadas as a reference over the typical butterfly from a cocoon. Can you elaborate on this? **A:** There are so many interesting things about their metamorphosis. They don’t disappear into this polite cocoon that is almost like a dressing room, where they can close the door, and there’s nice lighting when they emerge, and it is elegant. With cicadas, there is this vampire, horror-film quality. The back breaks; the cicada almost stands upright like Dracula coming out of the coffin, like it is being raised from the dead. Even the way the exoskeleton remains – like a phantom of the old self. It’s still there; you’re still haunted by the old self. I thought this is what it looks like when we change. **Q:** *Given the themes in the novel, what are your thoughts on women being boxed into domesticity and how that relates to labour?* **A:** There are many feminist



Avni Doshi’s debut novel was nominated for the Booker Prize in 2020.

writers that have influenced me. I’m really interested in Silvia Federici. I think it is this interesting, insidious trick of capitalism where everything is labour, all labour has a value, and we are all paid for our labour. The only arena where that is not the case is motherhood. Motherhood stands apart from every other sort of actor within the capitalist system. Motherhood and the raising of children, which is, if you look at it, the raising of citizens, is held apart. I was interested in playing with this way in which we essentialise nature into beauty, the way we essentialise beauty and womanhood, and motherhood into the natural. It is this trick, this conditioning, this way of framing that positions women and their work that it can never be compensated. That there can be no remuneration for work that is of one’s nature. To me, it is sort of a setup to keep women enslaved by their biology under patriarchy. **Q:** *Were there any goddesses and myths that inspired you while writing The First House?* **A:** With mythology, when I was younger, I thought a lot about the *Ramayana*. Something shifted when I started to hear more of the stories from the Shakta traditions. The story of Shiva and Kama – that has been a kind of interesting story to me. When I heard the story then told from the Shakta tradition, it became something totally different. I was interested in the Egyptian goddesses, the myth of Chhinnamasta – she beheads herself. All the Dasa Mahavidyas are fascinating. I am promiscuous, I’ll go any direction, any face the great mother wears, if that makes sense. **Q:** *After Burnt Sugar, did you want to do family dynamics again?* **A:** There is, of course, pressure when the first one does well, but when you are writing, the pressure evaporates. I am interested in very political things. One of the most fascinating ways to see a character’s politics is through their intimate relationships. You can stand up in front of people and give a great speech; you can get on a radio show and talk about politics, but how do you treat your wife at home, how do you raise your daughters? Family is where we are the most honest. I find that family dynamics are often the most interesting way of getting into the reality of a character. **The interviewer is a writer and consulting editor exploring stories on books, culture and art.**



(Clockwise from right) Stills from *Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge*, *Guide*, and *Mother India*. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



standing. Writing about Mehboob Khan's *Mother India* (1957), she compares it with his earlier treatment of the same story, *Aurat* (1940), noting that the older film treats the protagonist's story in more personal terms. She looks at the treatment of women characters by the Bengali masters Ritwik Ghatak and Ray, with an emphasis on the "cannibalising" of the hard-working Nita in Ghatak's *Meghe Dhaka Tara* (1960) by her own family, or Ray's treatment of the friendship between Arati and her Anglo-Indian colleague Edith, who can be seen as a victim of racism in reverse, in *Mahanagar* (1963). She celebrates the revitalising power of Waheeda Rehman's great snake dance at a pivotal point in *Guide* (1965). And she raises interesting questions, letting them hang in the air: what is the purpose – and what conflicting feelings might it evoke in a viewer – of the brief close-ups of "the naked breast of a nursing woman" in Nabyendu Chatterjee's *Parasuramer Kuthar* (1989)?

A mixed verdict
As for the writing itself, some of it is dry and repetitive. In one passage, listing the different layers of meaning carried by Radha's *kangans* (bangles) in *Mother India*, the author says exactly the same thing in points one and two: "First, they symbolise her uncertain marital status" followed by "Second, she does not know whether she is married, widowed, or a deserted wife". There are other examples of such tautology, a problem that has long afflicted much cinema writing in India in both the academic and general spheres.

Regardless of my overall reservations, I appreciated Chatterji's open-endedness and handling of complexity. At one point she suggests that though writer-director Gulzar is sensitive to his women characters, and careful not to subject them to an objectifying gaze even when the narrative offers such opportunities, he also seems conservative about the idea of the working woman or the woman in a position of power. That these contrary impulses exist in all artists, and often create conflicting energies in a film, is something that Chatterji, unlike many other analysts, is attentive to. You can disagree with some of her analyses while also admiring the seriousness that lies behind them.

The reviewer is a freelance writer and journalist based in New Delhi.

Jai Arjun Singh

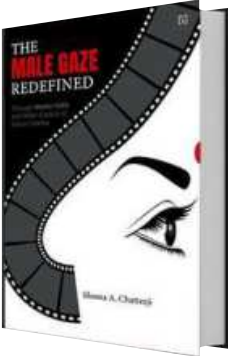
WAYS OF SEEING AND NOT SEEING

Though offering thoughtful insights into Indian cinema, Shoma Chatterji's book is hampered by datedness and a narrow focus

A book reviewer or a film reviewer often falls into the trap of judging a work by pre-set notions of what it ought to be, and fixating on exclusions. This is something any serious critic should be mindful of. Yet I must confess that some of my reservations about Shoma Chatterji's *The Male Gaze Redefined* are along those lines. Subtitled "Through Mother India and Other Classics of Indian Cinema", this book examines the works of nine major male directors in terms of the attitudes to women revealed in their films, spanning several decades. To elucidate her points about ways of looking and depicting, Chatterji also discusses, and occasionally argues with, Western film theory by Laura Mulvey and others.

Limited scope
This is a worthy project, and Chatterji, like any writer, is free to choose her area of study and to stay within its limits. In actual practice, though, things get tricky, because this is a freshly published book which makes many broad-based statements about Indian cinema, and doesn't define itself as dealing only with distant history. That being the case, one can raise an eyebrow at the datedness of some of its content. For instance, at the end of a

generally insightful chapter touching on idealised goddess representations of women, Chatterji refers to Mahesh Manjrekar (aged 67) and Rituparno Ghosh (who passed away 13 years ago) as "young directors" who are helping to change the zeitgeist. Despite fleeting references to recent works such as *Indu Sarkar* (2017) and *Thalaivii* (2021), the 21st century rarely impinges on this canvas. Some passages feel like they were excerpted from papers written decades ago. A section titled 'Silent Submission in Some Contemporary Films' boldly ventures to the mid-1990s (*Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge*), but no further.



The Male Gaze Redefined
Shoma A. Chatterji
Hachette India
₹499

Even a reader who is invested in deep film history may be perplexed about this book's unwillingness to engage with more recent

developments in feminist cinema. Timelines aside, the focus is almost exclusively on Hindi and Bengali films – with only a few quick notes at the end about directors such as Adoor Gopalakrishnan, Jabbar Patel, and Girish Kasaravalli. Further, Chatterji's main engagement is with auteurs who come from relatively progressive, modern backgrounds (Satyajit Ray, Mrinal Sen) or those who worked in what is called parallel/art or 'middle cinema' (Shyam Benegal, Gulzar). Notwithstanding the inclusion of

Vijay Anand's *Guide* (1965), there is not much effort here to discuss the many ways in which "male lens" cinema operates within the truly popular or mainstream.

Close readings
How best, then, to approach *The Male Gaze Redefined*? By reading the individual essays on their own terms, without bothering much about the larger picture. Seen this way, the book contains some thoughtful analysis, as you would expect from a scholar of Chatterji's

Sumana Mukherjee

In November 2019, in London, among the most surveilled cities in the world, a security camera captured a young man in a luxury high-rise on the banks of the Thames. It watched as he stepped out into the balcony in the middle of the night, walked from end to end before returning to the centre, and then pitched himself over, into nothingness, into the river. It was a matter of minutes, possibly seconds. But what led to those seconds? And what followed after?

Beyond the headlines
In the hands of seven different novelists, the story could move in seven different directions. None of them would be wrong, but none would be correct either. The willing suspension of disbelief – that unstated, ever-present compact between the reader and the novelist – would possibly ensure satisfaction, even closure: the kind achieved after a particularly good crime thriller.

In the hands of Patrick Radden Keefe, staff writer at *The New Yorker* and master of the art of narrative nonfiction, however, the narrative produces a range of takeaways: horror, fear, and caution, but also awe and wonder, respect, and understanding. If fiction takes one into places unventured and lives never lived, great narrative non-fiction, such as Keefe's, takes the reader deeper into the familiar, beyond the headlines. It connects dots and builds sequences riding on the fundamentals of good journalism: relentless reportage, endless time for the principals – for these are real people, not figments of the imagination – and the ability to sift through both and cohere the material into a gripping read reflective of reality.

Keefe's focus in *London Falling* is, first and foremost, the corrupted



London's dark underbelly

Patrick Radden Keefe's exceptional work traces one young man's tragic fall through a world of wealth, ambition, and deception

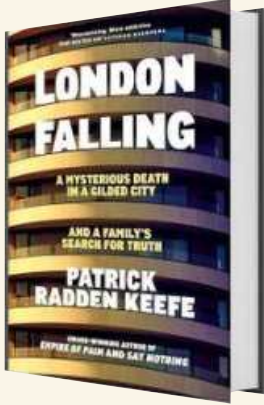
city. After multiple metamorphoses through history, London, at the cusp of the new millennium, reinvented itself – as Oliver Bullough brilliantly described in *Butler to the World* (2022) – as the capital of a nation that is "servant of tycoons, tax dodgers, kleptocrats and criminals".

Zac's world
Already a magnet for freshly minted oligarchs after the break-up of the USSR, London saw another influx in 2000 when Vladimir Putin, a

former KGB officer, assumed power in Russia. The same year, Rachelle and Matthew Brettler, a young, well-off city couple, gave birth to their second son, Zac. From early on, he demonstrated that he was funny, charismatic, and wildly intelligent, and perhaps also something of a fabulist. As Zac grew into adolescence, it became clear that his parents' world was not enough for him. When he changed schools as a teen, joining Mill



London is among the most surveilled cities in the world. A view of the Palace of Westminster; (below) Patrick Radden Keefe. (GETTY IMAGES)



London Falling
Patrick Radden Keefe
Picador
₹750

Hill, "a particularly attractive option to the children of foreign plutocrats", he started introducing himself as the son of an exiled Russian/Kazakh millionaire. In 2019, a casually cultivated acquaintance associated with the Chelsea Football Club (then owned by Russian oligarch Roman Abramovich) patched Zac through to Ugandan-Indian Akbar Shamji, a debonair man with an aura of wealth and success, and Verinder Sharma, a "rubber tycoon". At last, Zac seemed to have acquired a toehold in the world of the rich, famous and Insta-glamorous. Together, the three of them would strike deals – in real estate, oil, perhaps even drugs – and grow richer still. Shamji and Sharma were also the last people Zac saw ahead of his fatal fall. Towards the end of the book, after going down every rabbit hole, chasing every lead, Keefe summarises the story in a few lines. (Spoiler ahead.) A young man with ambition,

talent, and a self-proclaimed fortune had cosied up with two older men – shadier, more experienced, and far more desperate. Zac was naïve and inexperienced at 19, while the other two were nearing the end of their dubious careers, primed for one last big gamble. But who conned whom, and who paid the price?

The art of storytelling
As fascinating as that puzzle is, Keefe's real triumph lies in weaving the complex web that enables the relationship, starting with Zac's parents and their back stories, then delving into Shamji's father's flashy, unsubstantial businesses, and also touching on Sharma's early years in an immigrant Indian family. Through it all, London shape-shifts – loosening its economic regulations, losing its moral moorings, and becoming a city of the 21st century.

A few things went Keefe's way when he stumbled on the story in 2023: he had unlimited access to the Brettlers and their contemporaneous notes on the ordeal, including long conversations with the inexplicably underperforming Metropolitan Police. Intense research revealed Shamji's colourful, carefully elided past. And he was able to piece together enough of Sharma's arc to introduce the element of danger and violence that defined Zac's brief life. The success of *London Falling* is entirely down to Keefe's exceptional storytelling skills and his immense empathy which, somehow, never veers into either judgment or absolution. He seems to suggest that Zac's story belongs to all of us: to parents, siblings, friends, mentors, role models, institutions, and nation. Why, then, do we let him down again and again?

The reviewer is a writer based in Bengaluru.

CONTINUED FROM
PAGE 1

Snail mail clubs took off in the West around 2024-25. Now, subscribers counts are in the thousands, creators earn four- and five-figure monthly incomes, and the offerings range from art print and mystery mails to fantasy fiction, recipes, wellness and even the sensorial – think pressed flowers, envelopes scented with essential oils, and tactile ephemera such as vintage ticket stubs.

The clubs are now slowly finding an audience in India. Nagaland-based self-taught artist Tim Yanger's Orange Boy print club is popular in the country and abroad. Every month, he mails original prints, along with postcards, hand-cut vinyl stickers and bookmarks –

inspired by nostalgia and his childhood. In Mumbai, Diya Soni's Moo Mail Club translates her love for travel and animals into art prints, zines, and one 'un-rot activity'. In Hyderabad, Udita Gowdety's Mixed Monet club sends out mixed-media posters and prints of her canvas paintings.

For Megha Jeevan, a tattoo artist in Goa, starting her snail mail club, Scratching Post, seven months ago was a way to show up for herself. "Knowing that people are waiting for a letter every month holds me accountable to creating," she says. It was also a response to how fleeting "conversations and connections" are today despite people spending hours on WhatsApp and Instagram. For ₹599 a month, her small yet

tight-knit subscriber base (around 50, all aged between 23 and 40 years) gets an original artwork or two, stickers, a handwritten letter and a surprise gift – anything from puzzles to habit trackers.

For others like Richa Sharma, a club was a means to give her art a life beyond the digital feed. The Chandigarh-based software engineer, who had started showcasing her illustrations on Instagram in 2024, found herself wanting to create something that people could hold in their hands. Two months ago, she launched her art club, where "for ₹299, subscribers receive a postcard featuring my artwork, a sheet of stickers related to that month's theme, and a handwritten letter", she says.

Making of a ritual
This isn't just another trend, but a reaction to the instant gratification of online algorithms. And a return to the idea of ownership and permanence. "We often assume this is about nostalgia, but nostalgia requires memory," says Risha Bhattacharya, a Kolkata-based psychologist. "Most Gen Z and Gen Alpha consumers don't have lived memories of writing letters or listening to records in the way that previous generations do. They're looking for experiences that feel different from the digital environments they've always known. When every experience is designed to be immediate, there is very little opportunity to cultivate patience or immerse yourself in a single activity."



THE QUIET APPEAL OF SNAIL MAIL



(Clockwise from far left) Snail mail curations from Art by Richa Sharma, Mythbridge, and Tamarai Tales; and Tim Yanger of Orange Boy. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND @TIMY/ORANGEBOY

People are craving reasons to slow down today. "Reading a letter forces you to be present in a way a notification never does," says Viola Devassy, an illustrator from Mumbai, who started her snail mail initiative last December. Her subscribers look forward to her illustrated journaling materials, planning inserts, stickers and stationery – designed to encourage reflection and creativity, and create pockets of calm in their creative routines.

For most subscribers, the wait for the mail – building anticipation, delayed gratification – is part of the experience. So is the opportunity to 'touch grass' (step away from the screen and reconnect with the real world), as the youngsters put it. "I don't open an envelope immediately," says Greishma Ramesh, a 27-year-old IT professional from Coimbatore, for whom opening the envelope has become a ritual in itself. "I wait until I have some quiet time. Then I colour, journal or just sit with the prompts. It's become my way of disconnecting from my phone."

She keeps every mail she has received in a box, returning to them whenever she needs a moment of calm. "Sometimes, I just open the box and flip through them. They remind me to slow down. They've become little

keepsakes that I revisit." Harini, a 28-year-old event planner and new mother from Chennai, recalls how her mail arrived during a particularly vulnerable period. Postpartum recovery had left little room for herself, and the monthly envelopes became an unexpected source of comfort. "It felt very personal," she says. "Like someone had written exactly what I needed to hear."

'Friction creates meaning'
While snail mail is an antithesis of online algorithms, there's another force at play too, according to psychologist Bhattacharya – what she calls costuming identity. "Young people have always experimented with who they are," she says. "Today, that process is far more visible. People express themselves through the hobbies they adopt, the aesthetics they embrace, and the communities they join."

That helps explain one of the paradoxes of the analogue revival. A young person may discover snail mail, vinyl records or journaling through Instagram, spend hours immersed in those offline experiences, and later post about them on the very platform they briefly stepped away from.

Bhanuj Kappal, head of music programming at Idoru Bombay, offers an explanation for what makes these experiences so compelling. The answer, he suggests, lies in something modern technology has spent decades trying to eliminate: friction. "For the better part of two decades,

technology has been trying to remove friction from our lives," he says. "Whether it's ordering food in 10 minutes or streaming a film instantly, convenience has become the default."

That, he believes, is precisely why analogue formats have regained their appeal. "Friction creates meaning," he says. And in 2026, friction maxxing – or choosing to do things the hard way – is what people are looking for, to enjoy real-world experiences, help with focus, to better mental health.

Making a physical connection
Several thousand miles away in London, Tomas Jauregui,



RISHA BHATTACHARYA
Psychologist

a video games producer, spends much of his day doing something that would have sounded absurd a decade ago: using social media to convince people to sign up for his handwritten stories. Jauregui, a Cambridge MBA graduate, is the founder of Mythbridge, a fantasy-themed snail-mail community with nearly 1,800 members worldwide.

The project emerged from the atmosphere of COVID-era Cambridge, with its ancient colleges and empty streets. A long-time admirer of fantasy writer Terry Pratchett, Jauregui found himself spending hours building imaginary worlds of his own. "I wanted to see what would happen if I built an entire

fictional world that people could explore through letters."

In January 2025, he sent his first letter. Eighteen months later, Mythbridge has subscribers across the U.S., the U.K., Europe and Australia, with every envelope advancing an unfolding fantasy narrative through world-building and illustrated artefacts. What began as a creative experiment has since become his full-time occupation – sustained by



SOWBHARANIKA LAKSHIMIPATHY
Creator of Tamarai Tales

subscription revenue and now brand collaborations. His next ambition: to take that community beyond the mailbox, through meet-ups at bookshops, fantasy fairs and literary festivals.

If Jauregui represents the entrepreneurial face of the analogue revival, Bengaluru-based editor and arts manager Manju Sara Rajan sees it as part of a much larger cultural shift. She points to the growing popularity of fountain pens and handmade journals, objects that demand time and intention. "Writing with a fountain pen is a laborious exercise," she says. "You have to slow down, refill the ink and commit yourself to the act of writing." In an age of frictionless digital communication, she believes

Gen Z consumers are looking for experiences that feel different from the digital environments they've always known. When every experience is designed to be immediate, there is very little opportunity to cultivate patience

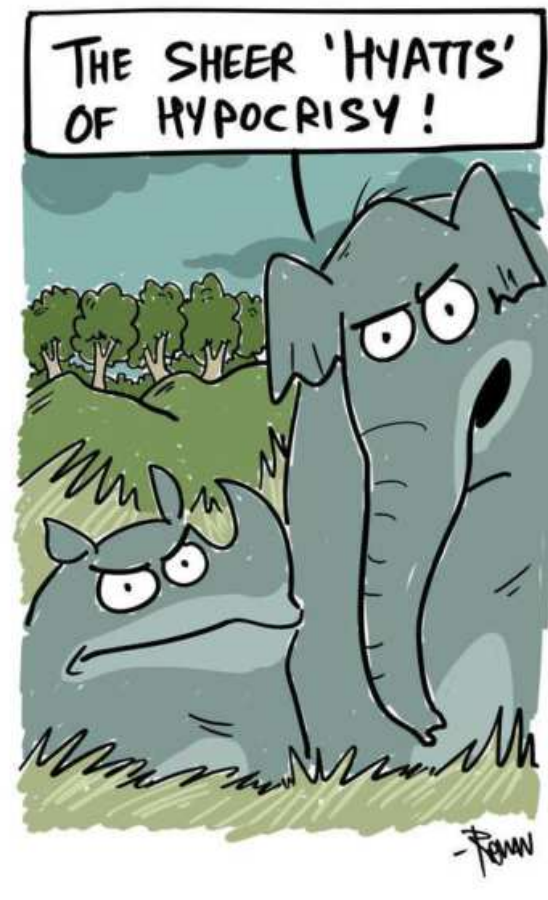
For the better part of two decades, technology has been trying to remove friction from our lives. Which is why analogue formats have regained their appeal, because friction creates meaning

For the better part of two decades, technology has been trying to remove friction from our lives. Which is why analogue formats have regained their appeal, because friction creates meaning

BHANUJ KAPPAL
Head of music programming, Idoru Bombay

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty



Rinchen Angmo Chumikchan

Art rarely stays within gallery walls in Ladakh. This August, it will be spreading across mountains, villages and open landscapes as the region hosts the inaugural Sā Ladakh Biennale (from the Ladakhi word *sā*, meaning soil). Titled *Signals from Another Star*, and positioned as the world's highest regenerative art biennale (at 3,000 m above sea level), it will bring together 26 Ladakhi and international artists.

Interestingly, the inaugural edition will have no opening or closing ceremonies, no ticketing, and no white cube galleries. Instead, it will unfold across eight sites stretching over 200 km, from Leh to Kargil – with three site-specific installations at each location, made from locally sourced natural materials.

The non-commercial format, where each site can only be reached on foot, invites visitors to experience not only artworks, but also the landscapes and people that shape them. "I wouldn't describe it as an anti-biennale," says co-founder Raki Nikahetiya. "The word 'anti'



ART AT HIGH ALTITUDE

Sā Biennale is transforming Ladakh's mountains and villages into sites of artistic expression, bringing contemporary art into conversation with ecology and community



rocks and vegetation to create art directly within the landscape) saw them launching Sā Ladakh, the precursor to the biennale, in the same year.

Changing your pace
The biennale is less about producing objects than it is about offering a different perspective. The setting itself reshapes the experience of viewing art. "At over 11,000 ft, altitude changes your pace, your breathing and your awareness," he says. "Walking between installations becomes part of the work. The silence, the intense light, the vastness of the mountains and the lived conversations with local communities all influence how the art is encountered."

For many associated with the project, the biennale also helps reflect Ladakh's culture and the realities of living in a region where climate and landscape shape everyday life. "Living here means being constantly aware of the

environment," says Monisha Ahmed, founder of Ladakh Arts and Media Organisation and a member of Sā Biennale's advisory board. "People here have a very intimate relationship with the land."

In Leh, for instance, the installations reflect the region's legacy as a historic crossroads of trade and faith, drawing on its monasteries and traditional architecture; at Mulbekh, they engage with the Maitreya Buddha and the rhythms of the pastoral landscape sustained by seasonal meltwater; and in Hundertman, Kargil, they are rooted in the village's Balti and Purgi heritage, and the lived experience of displacement and border life.

An evolving canvas
The newest biennale on the global map is also an opportunity to broaden global perceptions of Ladakh's artistic identity. "People know the region for its monasteries, murals and *thangkas*. When I

tell them we have contemporary artists, they are often surprised," Ahmed shares.

For many local artists, Sā has become an important platform. Contemporary artist Skarma Sonam Tashi says his participation in Sā Ladakh led to opportunities at the India Art Fair and the ongoing Venice Biennale, where he is part of the India Pavilion.

Contemporary artist Jigmet Angmo says that until recently, Ladakhi artists largely exhibited outside the region, mainly through LAMO. "Earlier, we were confined to our studios. Now, the landscape itself has become part of our art," says Angmo, who explored the impact of climate change on Ladakh's traditional architecture at Sā Ladakh 2023.

"Using clay as my medium, I created an installation that had to be covered with a plastic sheet when it rained. The gesture reflected a changing reality: Ladakh's mud houses were never designed to withstand frequent rainfall, but a changing climate is forcing both the landscape and its architecture to adapt."

'Not designed around scale'
As Sā Biennale readies for its first edition, the organisers insist that it will remain an evolving process rather than a fixed model. Future editions will continue to respond to changing communities and landscapes.

Also, rather than measuring success by visitor numbers, the Biennale is interested in the quality of engagement. "Sā Biennale is not designed around spectacle or scale," says Nikahetiya. "We hope visitors leave with a deeper understanding of Ladakh, its people and the ideas explored by the artists. If art can encourage curiosity and responsibility, then it has achieved something meaningful."

Sā Ladakh Biennale is on from August 1 to 10. Entry to all sites is free.

The senior multimedia journalist from Ladakh writes on the region's environment, culture and public affairs.



ALLEGEDLY

Going to Jantar Mantar

Maybe it's at least worth checking out (without supporting it)

Regular readers of this column would know me as a strong believer in democracy and dissent. They would also know me as a 100-times stronger believer in national integrity, in the unity, integrity and sovereignty of India, and most important of all, in the sanctity of public order. So, I had no intention whatsoever of being anywhere within a 10-mile radius of the foreign-funded protest unfolding at Jantar Mantar.

But then, on July 20, thousands of youngsters went and smashed their heads and bodies against the lathis of innocent policemen. The marauding students screamed so much that tear gas canisters popped out of the sky. Pellets materialised from thin air and embedded themselves in young bodies. All this made me curious. I felt an urge to see for myself what was going on. But I resisted the temptation, lest people misread my motives and assume that I was there to support the cockroaches.

If I ended up changing my mind, the credit goes to one man: Sachin Tendulkar. I couldn't help but be moved, and inspired, by his passionate statement of unequivocal support for the protesting students. I thought, if even Sachin is courageously standing by India's youth,

maybe it's at least worth checking out (without supporting it).

Looking for company
But I didn't want to go alone. So, I asked my third-best friend, Alok, if he wanted to come along. He still owed me ₹10 for a beer we shared in 2014 that he was supposed to pay for but never did. I thought, in case the police stopped me and started asking questions, I could point to Alok and tell them it was his idea.

Unfortunately, Alok proved smarter than I expected. "I can't," he said. "My passport is coming up for renewal." "You have a passport appointment at 7 in the evening?" "No, no," he said. "My appointment was yesterday. It's done."

"Then what's the problem?" "They have cameras everywhere. Latest facial recognition tech. I'm not taking any risk until I have the new passport in my hand."

I asked my second-best friend, a GenXer like myself. He said he can't because he had plans to watch *The Odyssey* that evening. My best friend, a millennial, also refused, saying, "Paper leaks happened during UPA time also. It's nothing new. NEET re-test happened and all went well. This is a time-waste protest."

I walk alone
Fine, I said to myself. I'll go on my own.

On Thursday, as I was leaving for work, I announced, "I may not be reachable between 7 and 10 in the evening." "Why not," Wife said. "Going to a new watering hole where mobile phones are banned?" "I wouldn't call Jantar Mantar a watering hole," I said. "Though there is a small chance of water cannons."

"What? Why do YOU have to go there?"

"Once an anti-national, always an anti-national," my mother said, disgusted. "Papa, you are going to Jantar Mantar?" Katta said. "Can I also come?"

"Def, you are Gen Alpha. Why are you interested?" I was mildly alarmed.

"You said you will take me to a historical monument this year."

"I will," I said. "But not to Jantar Mantar."

"But why are you going?" Wife persisted. "You're not even Gen Z."

"He secretly thinks of himself as Gen Z," Amma said. "I'm a journalist," I said. "I owe it to the people of India to go and check it out."

"All the Metro stations there are shut," Wife said. "How will you go?" "I'll manage."

"There is also an Internet shutdown."

"That's why I said I may not be reachable."

"What if they use tear gas?" "That would be amazing," I said. "I can write about it in my memoir."

"Don't be ridiculous," she said. "Let me get you a wet towel."

"Hello! I am not taking any towel-vowel."

"Let him go there and shed tears for democracy," Amma said. "He deserves both lathi-charge and tear gas."

"Stop Amma," Wife said. "Emma stop?" Amma said.

"These cockroaches are throwing such vile abuses at Modi ji! And this fellow wants to go and cheer them on!"

"I am not going there to cheer anyone," I said. "I am going there as a neutral, objective observer. To document facts."

"Don't I know what sort of 'facts' you're going there to document?"

"I don't understand why she doesn't understand," I said. "Okay, you better leave now," Wife said, pushing me out the door. "Download offline maps on Google Maps. Stay safe."

As I started down the stairs, I heard Katta yell, "Remember to take photos of Jantar Mantar!"

G. Sampath, the author of this satiric column, is Social Affairs Editor, The Hindu.

PERSON OF INTEREST

AISHE GHOSH: SPEAKING UP MATTERS

A veteran of the 2019 anti-CAA protests reflects on a new generation of student dissent and the lessons it must carry forward

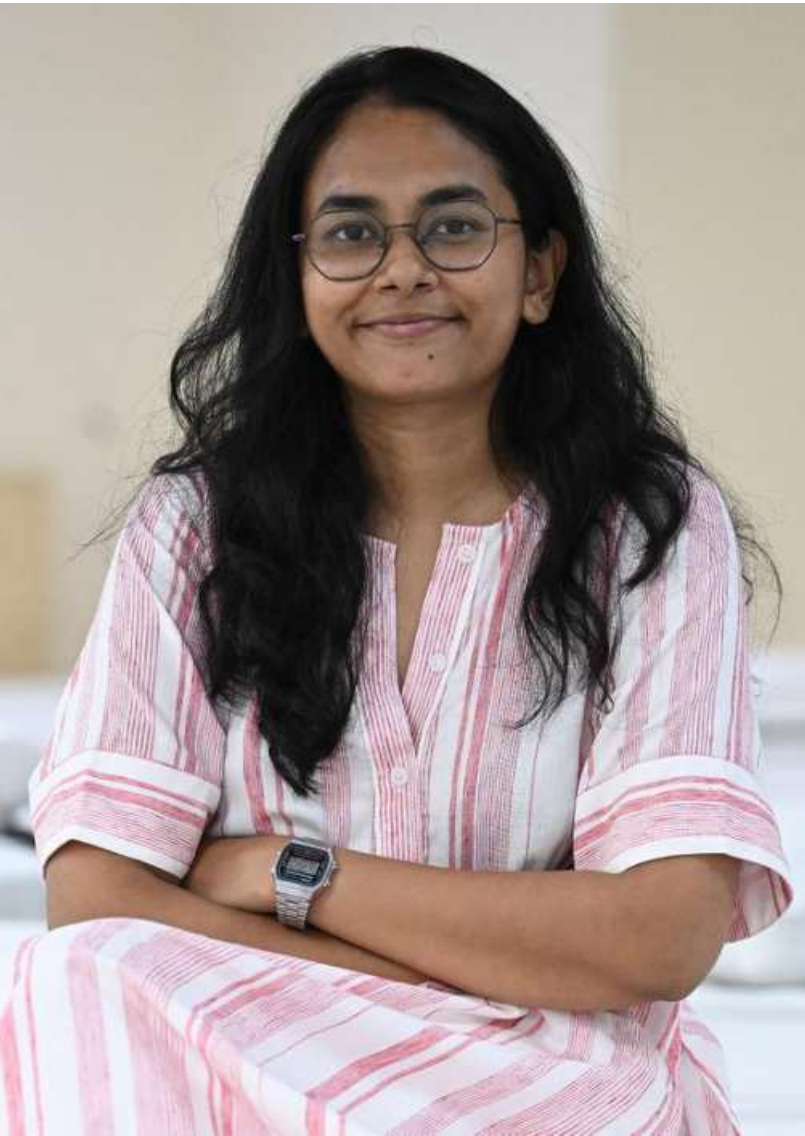
Long before the police lathi-charged the Gen Z protesters in Delhi, Aishe Ghosh was attacked by masked men wielding iron rods, sticks and acid, on her college campus in January 2020, as the police stood by. A photo of the petite student leader, injured after she confronted the attackers, blood pouring down her forehead, went viral then.

Ghosh, now 30, was at the Jantar Mantar protests from the start and participated in a symbolic three-day fast when activist Sonam Wangchuk was hauled out of the venue by the Delhi Police. Her postmortem of the biggest protest India has seen in years is important because she was at the forefront of the 2019 protests against the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) and the National Register of Citizens (NRC). “We were the Gen Z of that moment,” she says, confirming that she feels a strong sense of déjà vu.

When the anti-CAA/NRC protests began, Ghosh, who represented left-wing student groups (Students’ Federation of India, SFI), was a freshly-minted student union president at Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU). She had won with a comfortable margin against her rival from the Hindu right.

The protests deeply impacted Ghosh, who had grown up in industrialised Durgapur, West Bengal, with a machine operator father and a homemaker mother. Her father was associated with a labour organisation and she was familiar with trade unions and strikes. In 2021, she became the first sitting president of the JNU students’ body to contest an Assembly election. She fought on a CPI(M) ticket and lost. She remains the national joint secretary of the SFI.

From fear to hope
The days Ghosh has spent at the protest called by the Cockroach



Aishe Ghosh is the national joint secretary of the Students’ Federation of India. (SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA)

with CJP leaders at the forefront of the protests. They marvelled at the unique manner in which this generation dissents, their creativity and positivity, and at the melting pot of caste, religion and region that assembled at Jantar Mantar. “They already know how the propaganda works,” she says. “The best part of this movement is that it has made people fearless. There is a large segment of people saying, ‘What are you going to do? We don’t care’.”

Political awareness
Older students like Ghosh, who have been fighting against the commodification of education, utilised the gathering to give younger protesters a daily history lesson about systemic failures and injustices. They told them about anti-CAA student protesters such as Umar Khalid and Sharjeel Imam who are still in jail six years later, charged under stringent terrorism laws. “I personally feel that when we are speaking about this government’s anti-student policies, we can’t avoid speaking about them,” she says. That makes sense because those names are anathema to the security establishment, even in a Congress-ruled Karnataka, where their names on a placard during the NEET protest sparked a police FIR.

They also spoke of university students Rohith Vemula and Payal Tadvi who died of suicide because of caste-based harassment. They introduced young protesters to S. Anitha, who fought in the Supreme

Court against the implementation of NEET in 2017 because it was skewed against poor students, and later died by suicide.

Ghosh says that since the people leading the recent protests have not been a part of the country’s long-running students’ movement, the responsibility of veteran student leaders is to ensure that the protesters learn about the bigger picture before they head back home. “Protests politicise people. So many students who were never a part of any politics have spoken here,” she says. “Victory is one thing but as second-line organisers, can we empower them to speak up when they go back home?”

Thanks to her influence, her family has become more political. “Family gatherings are no more just about personal lives; somewhere the political discussions come up,” she says. “My mother hardly used to speak about politics, but now she is very updated about what is happening.” Days after the latest protest ended, the Delhi Police attempted to arrest Ghosh in connection with a 2021 case.

She never thought she would see such a rebellion, where the youth would come together and speak up so openly. “A lot of people have been on the verge of speaking up every day since 2014, and it makes those of us who have spoken up these past 12 years hopeful. All our work has not gone in vain,” she says. “Speaking up matters. This movement is a reflection of that.”

Priya Ramani is a Bengaluru-based journalist and the co-founder of India Love Project on Instagram.

GOREN BRIDGE

The fallback

Both vulnerable. South deals

NORTH
♥ Q J
♦ 6 5 3 2
♠ A 7 2
♣ 9 8 6 3

WEST
♠ 8 6 5 4 2
♥ 10 9
♦ 10 5
♣ Q J 7 4

EAST
♠ K 10 7 3
♥ 8 4
♦ J 9 8 6 4 3
♣ 10

SOUTH
♠ A 9
♥ A K Q J 7
♦ K Q
♣ A K 5 2

The bidding:
SOUTH 2♣
2♥
3♠
6♥

WEST Pass
Pass
Pass
All pass

NORTH 2♦
3♥
4♦

EAST Pass
Pass
Pass

Opening lead: 10 of ♥

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

All you need to know about designers



An ash tray designed for an Indian airline by Salvador Dali.

Surrealist artist Salvador Dali once designed an ashtray for an airline. Instead of money, he reportedly accepted payment in the form of a baby elephant, which was flown from Bengaluru to Geneva. Which airline commissioned the ashtray for its First Class cabins?

While this product’s design dates back thousands of years, the modern rubber version traces its origins to Japanese zōri sandals. Scotsman Robert Fraser created one of the first mass-produced rubber-soled designs in 1958. By 1962, the Brazilian brand Havaianas popularised it worldwide, and Americans called it ‘Flip-Flops’. The Asian community calls it by what name?

When Alastair Curtis created this design for a Finnish telecommunications company, its defining feature was the absence of a protruding external antenna. Released in 1999, it later became famous for its durability and toughness. Which iconic handset was it?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called ‘Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion’.

Berty Ashley

Born on August 2, 1834, Frédéric Auguste Bartholdi was a French sculptor. During a visit to Egypt, he proposed a monumental lighthouse for the Suez Canal titled ‘Egypt Carrying the Light to Asia’, but the project was never commissioned. He later adapted some of those ideas for a gift from France to the United States. By what name do we know this iconic monument today?

Born on August 2, 1865, John Radecki was an Australian artist renowned for mastering an art form that has adorned churches and cathedrals for centuries. Using coloured glass to create luminous images, what art form did he specialise in?

Born on August 2, 1876, geologist Pingali Venkayya, serving in the British Indian Army during the Second Boer War in South Africa, was not happy saluting the Union Jack. In 1921, he presented Mahatma Gandhi with a design that evolved into one of India’s most recognisable national symbols. What was it?

One of the world’s most ubiquitous designs began life as the Fauteuil 300, created by French designer Henry Massonnet in 1972. Moulded from a single piece of plastic, the item became known as monobloc. What everyday object, celebrated in museums and featured on the cover of a 2025 Grammy-winning album, is this?

communication product in 2007, its minimalist appearance, dominated by a touchscreen with almost no physical buttons, transformed the industry and the way people interact with technology. What product was it?

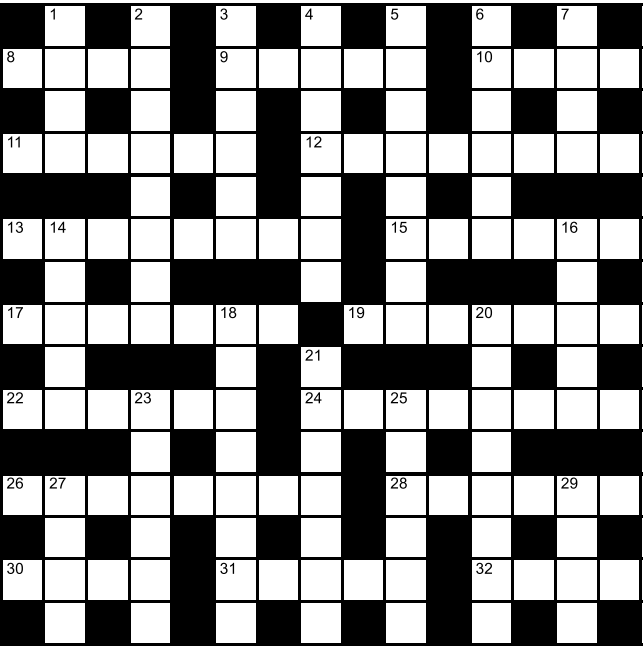
On July 1, 1979, a portable cassette player was launched, which became so influential that its name entered the Oxford English Dictionary as a generic term. Developed with the support of Norio Ohga, what was this product called?

British inventor Hilary Page patented the Self-Locking Building Brick in 1939. Several years later, a Danish toy company developed its own interlocking plastic bricks using a similar concept and turned them into a worldwide phenomenon. Which company was it?

- 1. Statue of Liberty
- 2. Steamed glass
- 3. Tricolour or the Indian national flag
- 4. Plastic chair
- 5. iPhone
- 6. Sony Walkman
- 7. LEGO
- 8. Air India
- 9. Hawaïi chappal
- 10. Nokia 3210

Answers

THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 67 (Set by Incognito)

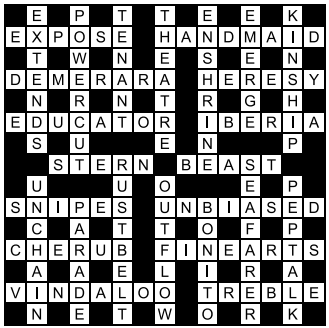


- Across**
- 8 Attire available in Amritsar, India (4)
 - 9 Excitedly goes around lecturer and stares lustfully (5)
 - 10 Father leaves Apache in pain (4)
 - 11 Surplus obtained from old tax (6)
 - 12 Snakelike Hopi and I danced (8)
 - 13 Arrange as region is quaking (8)
 - 15 Wonderland visitor follows maiden displaying spite (6)
 - 17 Draught animal and stag running around lake left by beginning of October (7)
 - 19 Silly ass accepts a container to get fruits (7)
 - 22 Before morning, you and I start to buy costly computer accessory (6)
 - 24 Drains go around street board (4,4)
 - 26 Poem composed about fluttering flag is a big failure (8)
 - 28 One tailless animal follows another bird (6)
 - 30 European on a street gets direction (4)
 - 31 Sound made by head of team near small stream (5)
 - 32 Politician’s attempt to consume egg (4)

- Down**
- 1 Mummy getting right cross for political thinker (4)
 - 2 Twisted wire put during autumn to create protective feature (8)
 - 3 In France, good saint gives up book for miniature tree (6)
 - 4 Fully finished everywhere (3,4)

- 5 Setter swings his mace, resulting in restricted blood supply (8)
- 6 Cut up sal and another kind of tree (6)
- 7 Bird not at home in Rhine area (4)
- 14 Love included in mysterious true path (5)
- 16 Rock in Scotland, rolling cigar (5)
- 18 Utter, “Totally” (8)
- 20 Old student only gets a note: “Outdated” (8)
- 21 Puzzling scream by police constable carrying that thing back (7)
- 23 Unsoiled church seat is broken (6)
- 25 Lamb preparation consumed in Alcoholics Anonymous in city (6)
- 27 Dash from crashed plane after losing first portion (4)
- 29 United States captures some foreign and alien spaceships, perhaps (4)

SOLUTION NO. 66



Why an apple?
Why not a peach
or an orange?

Thieyana Nagaraj
thieyana87@gmail.com

There must have been at least thousands of fruits in the Garden of Eden. Why was the apple selected as the fruit of knowledge? Why was this fruit responsible for enticing humans to attain knowledge and at the same time carry the negative connotation of being partly responsible for the exit of humans from the peaceful Garden of Eden?

This doesn't stop with biblical times.

In Greek mythology, apples are mentioned again and again. Retrieving the three golden apples belonging to Goddess Hera becomes the toughest eleventh labour of Heracles.

A golden apple with an inscription "For the fairest" was thrown by Goddess Eris at a wedding feast, leading to a fierce competition between Goddesses Hera, Athena, and Aphrodite. Prince Paris, the judge, gave it to Goddess Aphrodite, as she had offered him the most beautiful woman in the world as a bribe. It became the starting point of the great Trojan War as Paris abducted Helen of Troy.

William Tell, archer, was forced to shoot the apple that was placed on the head of his son from a distance of 120 yards by a tyrannical overlord.

No one could forget the fairy tale where Snow White is poisoned by an apple by her evil stepmother. Why couldn't it have been a pear or a strawberry?

There is Isaac Newton, who realised the entire concept of gravity by the falling of an apple on his head when he was snoozing under an apple tree. Thank god, he was not sitting under a coconut tree; that would have been a debacle.

An apple symbol – that too a half-bitten one – holds the utmost sway over the heart of any tech-savvy person. The long queue that forms in front of Apple stores to buy their new releases at periodic intervals is a testament to that.

There I was, sitting at a hospital waiting for a check-up, thinking about the unfair advantage the apple enjoys when compared with other fruits and sympathising with them for the partial treatment. My thoughts kind of bubbled over, and I voiced a few of these thoughts to my husband, and he looked at me incredulously. He said in a superior manner, "There is a war going on. The world is under a nuclear threat. The fuel prices are going up. The dollar value is increasing. You are worried about the 'unfair treatment' of fruits."

The doctor entered at that exact moment and started talking about my iron deficiency, vitamin deficiencies and the importance of eating more fruits and vegetables. The good doctor said, "After all, we all know that 'an apple a day keeps the doctor away' ... What do you say?"

Yesudas Pillai

yesudas@ynatransformation.com

India is often celebrated as the world's youngest democracy. We usually discuss that in the context of economic growth, startups, innovation and consumption. We should also discuss what it means for democracy.

For decades, India's youth have largely been viewed as an economic resource. It is time political parties begin viewing them as a democratic force.

The recent unrest around the NEET paper leak and the emergence of the CJP movement have triggered sharp political debates. Every political party, irrespective of ideology, has historically sought to ride public movements. Equally, many movements themselves have eventually evolved into political platforms. That is neither new nor uniquely Indian. There are already competing narratives around the antecedents and motivations of the current movement. But that isn't the most interesting question.

The real question is this: Why did it resonate? If a movement that reportedly began as online satire can bring young people onto the streets across parts of the country, it reflects something deeper than social media virality. It reflects accumulated frustration. Whether that frustration is entirely justified, partially justified or emotionally amplified is almost secondary. Public sentiment rarely explodes overnight. It accumulates.

The Malayalam film *One*, starring Mammooty, explores the idea of the Right to Recall, where 50% voters in a constituency can remove an elected representative who fails to deliver. Whether or not such a law is practical in India, it asks a question every democracy should answer: Must accountability wait until the next election?

Watching Parliament today is often disheartening. Representatives entrusted with our mandate increasingly resemble participants in televised shouting contests rather than custodians of democracy.

The tragedy isn't disagreement. Democracy requires disagreement. The tragedy is that disagreement has replaced governance. Many citizens voted hoping for balance. A government that governs. An opposition that questions.

Instead, we often witness obstruction on one side and defensiveness on the other, while issues affecting ordinary citizens quietly slip off the national agenda.

Rewarding outrage

Sadly, this behaviour has escaped Parliament and entered our everyday conversations. Television debates reward outrage. Social media rewards certainty. Listening has become weakness. Changing one's opinion has become betrayal. We debate not to discover truth but to prove the other side wrong. But in business, organisations and families, we solve problems very differently.

We listen. We negotiate. We search for common ground. Why should politics be any different?



ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R. KUMAR

Youth angst that should worry every political party

A politically aware generation numbering tens of crores possesses the potential to reshape electoral outcomes, not necessarily by protesting, but simply by voting with purpose

Our political conversations increasingly resemble ideological battlefields. Capitalism creates wealth but often struggles with equitable distribution.

Communism emphasises distribution while frequently weakening incentives for wealth creation. Must societies always choose between extremes? Or should mature democracies constantly search for better balance?

Progress has rarely emerged from absolute positions. It has emerged from thoughtful synthesis. May be politics deserves the same maturity. The statistics tell an interesting story. Around 37 crore Indians are between 15 and 29 years of age. Nearly 75 crore Indians are below the age of 30. A politically aware generation numbering tens of crores possesses the potential to reshape electoral outcomes, not necessarily by protesting, but simply by voting with purpose. Every political party should find that thought both inspiring and unsettling. Young Indians today are more connected, more informed and more vocal than any generation before them.

If they begin participating in elections with the same intensity with which they participate online, political calculations across the country could change dramatically. Not because they support one ideology. But since they begin demanding performance.

The moment opposition parties openly embrace a movement, or the movement itself appears comfortable becoming an extension of partisan politics, the ordinary

citizen begins asking uncomfortable questions. Who is really benefiting from this anger? That question does not invalidate the grievances. It simply reminds us that public trust depends on perceived independence. A movement driven by students must continue to look like a movement driven by students. Otherwise, its moral authority weakens. Governments cannot ignore genuine public anguish. Unaddressed frustration has a way of finding larger and less predictable expressions.

History repeatedly demonstrates that. But citizens, too, must confront uncomfortable truths. Paper leaks do not happen in isolation. They exist because someone leaks them. Someone purchases them. Someone profits from them. Corruption survives only when both supply and demand exist. We cannot condemn the system while quietly participating in it whenever it suits us. The real lesson from the recent unrest is not about one examination, one movement or one political party. It is about the changing relationship between citizens and power.

Imagine a democracy where governments admit mistakes. Where oppositions contribute solutions instead of just amplifying outrage. Where debates generate ideas instead of insults. Where voters reward performance rather than permanent ideological loyalty.

That may sound idealistic. But then, every meaningful democratic reform once sounded unrealistic. Until it happened.

FEEDBACK

Letters to the Magazine can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

The protests reflect years of accumulated frustration over jobs and exam leaks, not sudden anger. ('India's young and the breaking point'; July 26) Independent audit bodies for competitive exams, vacancies filled on schedule, and regular dialogue with youth groups would do more to restore trust than any assurance issued after the wrongdoing.

A. Myilsami

The resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan as demanded by the agitating students is a clear win for them. Arguably, a lot more needs to be done as the present examination system has been ridden with a deeper malaise. But one thing is for sure that India's youth is awakened and will not stop till their goal is achieved.

G. Ramasubramanyam

Nurturing talent

Reading about Gulzar's early days in Mumbai, one is struck by how a struggling migrant found sustenance in poetry readings and shared meals at Irani cafes. ('City of Gulzar'; July 26) That spirit of accessible culture is vanishing from our cities. Municipal corporations could easily support small community libraries and open readings in public spaces.

Nurturing writers does not always require grand institutions, just a room to gather.

Abbharna Barathi

Understanding history

This extract is a reminder of how fragile the arrangements around

Partition were. ('When Jinnah looked to Delhi'; July 26) Such histories deserve wider readership. School textbooks could include more such primary accounts, letting students see Partition as a sequence of human decisions rather than an inevitable event.

K. Sakunthala

Preserving the voice

The review rightly flags how translation can sometimes dilute a writer's voice with unnecessary embellishment. ('Unflinching portrait of Dalit life'; July 26) A translator's primary job is fidelity, not improvement. Readers deserve the author's actual voice, especially when the subject is a lived experience as stark as this.

M. Barathi

Eyes everywhere

The essay makes a fair point about screenshots as an outlet in an over-monitored digital life. ('In screenshots we trust'; July 26) But this habit also enables harassment and out-of-context sharing. Platforms should let users know when a shared post has been screenshotted in bulk or reposted elsewhere, without violating genuine privacy.

S.M. Jeeva

Correction

In the 'Easy like Sunday morning' quiz on July 26, 2026, the answer to Question 9 should have been 'lettuce'. The error is regretted.

— Editor.

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Friedrich Nietzsche, in *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, uses a child metaphor: "The child is innocence and forgetting, a new beginning, a game, a self-rolling wheel, a first movement, a sacred Yes." Here, Nietzsche's concept of the child represents the highest spiritual development: spontaneity, presence in the moment, free-spirited playfulness, and creativity. This stirs in me a deeper reflection on children's spiritual growth in contemporary times.

I grew up listening to my mother's childhood memories. As a little girl, her days were like an open canvas, all hers to paint. She could spend entire days outdoors, wandering through the vast mango orchard. Together with friends, she could freely explore the seasonal haats and melas. Through these stories, I could almost see my mother as a little girl, giggling and squealing with joy.

Time passed, and life gently guided my mother into adulthood, making space for my own childhood to begin.

Nurture children's spiritual growth

In a divided and anxious world, the spiritual flourishing of children is something that is largely forgotten



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

As a child, time was on my side. I could easily sneak out of the house to play in the neighbourhood. My mother would call me back only when it was too late. I was obsessed with collecting materials scattered around the house that could give tangible wings to my ideas. I used to plead with my tailor to give me fabric scraps and shimmering threads to adorn my creations. I was drawn to role play and was fond of trying outfits far larger than

myself. Some days, I would become a doctor who healed magically; on others, a salon expert offering crazy beauty services to customers (my parents and grandparents). Playing "teacher" was my biggest fascination.

Our elders were uncomplicated and encouraging. I fondly remember our New Year home fairs, when we transformed our *Dadi's* living room into a lively fairground with food stalls, games, and

art corners, all managed by us children. Most eagerly awaited were our riverbank picnics, which brought together our entire extended family to bask in laughter.

My most sacred moments came in boredom, through daydreams. I would imagine my *Nani's* elephant in her ancestral home or myself climbing a beam of sunlight streaming through a high window. In times of despair, daydreams became my companion, helping me cope with the loneliness of not fitting in at school.

Now, let us look at the hectic lives of children today.

Children today walk a precarious tightrope. They live in virtual world, burdened by high academic pressures and closely monitored schedules. Parents are bound to become tiger parents, waging strict rules for high academic and social excellence.

The quality of children's play is declining. The joy of spontaneous, creative, and imaginative play (such as make-believe or dramatic play) is being replaced by mechanistic engagements. Children play mostly with market toys and technologies that come with sophisticated, ready-made instructions and

predefined outcomes. While they may offer entertainment, skill-building, or a sense of achievement, they rarely inspire a child to discover something truly new and intimate to her. Spontaneous dramatic play, in that sense, is irreplaceable. Discussing the significance of dramatic play, Ruth Hartley and her colleagues, in their 1952 book *Understanding Children's Play*, cited Susan Isaac: "When the child plays at being father and mummie and the family of babies, the giant and the giant killer, the wild animal and the hunter, the teacher and the pupils, the policeman and the bus driver, he is externalizing his inner drama - the various aspects of his inner personality..."

A child's awakening of spirit is the highest form of learning. In today's divided and anxious world, the spiritual flourishing of children has become a priority we have largely forgotten. We are raising successful children, but not whole ones. It is more important than ever that we nurture children's inner life and those quiet, meaningful moments of spiritual growth. Let us take intentional steps in this direction.



SISTERHOOD OF DEFIANCE

At Kensington Palace, *The Last Princesses of Punjab* reopens a silenced chapter of dispossession

Uthra Rajgopal

On the front cover of Sikh historian Peter Bance's *The Last Royals of Lahore*, Princess Catherine is captured in a studio portrait of quiet, distant contemplation. Her head is draped loosely in shimmering silk; her necklaces and pearls radiate an old-world opulence that seems to weigh heavily upon her.

At first glance, these are the standard accoutrements of Indian royalty. But look closer: her earring is not pierced through the ear, but held by a fine, looped thread. It is a silent act of defiance, a sartorial compromise that allowed her to inhabit her South Asian identity without transgressing the Victorian social norms that deferred ear piercing for young girls. It is an almost invisible detail, yet it reveals the deep tensions of a lost empire surfacing through the fault lines of adornment.

There is a profound, perhaps bruising, irony in Kensington Palace hosting an exhibition on three sisters who grew up in exile. It was within these gilded rooms that the British Crown once charted the very empire that forcibly removed their father from his homeland. Daughters of Maharaja Duleep Singh, the last deposed Sikh ruler of Punjab, and raised within the orbit of Queen Victoria, the sisters – Sophia, Catherine and Bamba – occupy a complex historical position.

The Last Princesses of Punjab manages to reopen a silenced chapter of dispossession. This is not a narrative told through the blunt force of conquest, but through the intimate fragments of queens and princesses – silk garments, personal letters and fading photographs. Their lives remain suspended between the lost glorious homeland of Punjab and their forced displacement in Britain.

Tragic family history

The exhibition's entrance features a mise-en-scène of stylised trunks stamped with addresses, a cinematic montage, and a family tree set against a pale pink backdrop – a chromatic nod to their mother, Bamba Müller, whose name in Egyptian-Arabic bears that rosy hue. The family history is one of tragic complexity.

The father: Maharaja Duleep Singh, the boy-king who at 10 years old was forced to sign away the Koh-i-Noor and his kingdom, becoming a favourite of Queen Victoria who viewed him with a certain exotic adoration. The mother: Bamba, the daughter of a German banker and his Abyssinian mistress, raised by missionaries in Cairo and introduced to Duleep after he found himself an outcast in British matrimonial circles.

The matriarch: their paternal grandmother Maharani Jind Kaur, the lion-hearted queen who once led armies. Though she appears only in fragments in the exhibition, her story sharpens our understanding of



what was lost: not only sovereignty, but a lineage of female political authority. For the first time, her 1863 portrait by artist George Richmond is paired with a preparatory sketch and her personal jewellery – a pearl and gold necklace with matching *jhumkas*. A poignant caption reveals that while 525 items of her jewels were returned to her in London, it was on the cruel condition that she never return to India.

Conceptualised and curated by Polly Putnam and Mishka Sinha, the exhibition shifts from dispossession to defiance. We meet Princess Sophia, not as an ornament of empire, but as a firebrand suffragette selling *The Suffragette* newspaper at the gates of Hampton Court Palace in 1913.

While her public activism and her role as a Red Cross nurse during World War I are well-documented,

the exhibition offers a more intimate inventory of her life. We see her love of dogs, a prize-winning Pomeranian, her 1920s silver cigarette lighter, and her coral-encrusted cuticle cutters. These items paint a picture of a privileged life suspended between two worlds, culminating in her final wish: her ashes were taken by her sister to be laid to rest in Lahore.

A narrative that is not fixed

If Sophia's defiance was public, Princess Catherine's was private and radical. The exhibition highlights her decades-long relationship with her German governess, Lina Schäfer. In the vocabulary of the early 20th century, their bond was shielded as an "intimate friendship", but here it is presented as Catherine's most profound act of sovereignty – a diaspora within a diaspora where



(Clockwise from far left) A women's suffrage poster; exhibits at *The Last Princesses of Punjab*; Catherine, Bamba and Sophia Duleep Singh at their debutante ball at Buckingham Palace (1895); a handmade rocking horse; a *makara* head enameled gold bangle; Maharaja Duleep Singh's purple velvet evening jacket; poster for a women's suffrage event; a portrait of Maharani Jind Kaur; three Banares silk *dupattas* hang in stepped formation; and princess Catherine with her governess Lina Schäfer. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



return – resist any singular narrative. Instead, they form a constellation of movements and identities spanning continents.

Questions of belonging

Eschewing spectacle, *The Last Princesses of Punjab* unfolds through carefully composed spaces that privilege atmosphere and reflection. Arched alcoves, plush red carpeting, soft illumination and a pink and green palette evoke South Asian architectural forms, Victorian interiors, gendered spaces and suffragette symbolism.

Material culture serves as the ultimate narrative device. Three stunning magenta Banares silk *dupattas* hang in still silence, in a stepped formation, while a massive red woollen shawl with gold embroidery signals Bamba's reclamation of her title as the Queen of Punjab.

However, amongst all the textiles and dresses, it is her bespoke *lehenga* that signals hybridity. A European tailored skirt with pleats, dipped hemline at the back, and made from Banares silk brocade with a gold creeper pattern. The border is equally stunning – finely woven *zari* depicting a densely packed diamond-shaped pattern, known as nightingale's eye. A performative dimension of identity

adapting East and West cloth and fashion.

Beyond the biographies, the exhibition asks modern questions about belonging. The voices of Sikh people living in Britain today are peppered throughout. Amongst them, a group of creative women: Semira Badesha, Harpreet Nandha and Symrath Patti, who state, "The sisterhood among the three princesses and their acts of resistance resonated with us. We wanted to show the importance of community and empower others to be freely creative, despite the barriers they may face."

These voices are further highlighted by two contemporary neon art works by the highly acclaimed British artist, Chila Kumari Singh Burman. *Spangled Sun* (2020) honours the multi-cultural world of Maharani Jind Kaur while *Suffragette Luv* (2026) depicts poet and activist Sarojini Naidu and lawyer-activist Mithan Lam, both leading figures of the Women's Indian Association. But given the boldly graphic, almost pop art-style headline poster for the exhibition, there could have been more of an insight into this creative artwork rather than just commissioning contemporary artworks, which would have been better placed in an exhibition of their own.

Diasporic rebellion

As curator Putnam notes, Kensington Palace, once the childhood home of Queen Victoria – and the godmother to Sophia – offers a fitting setting to explore these entangled histories. "The exhibition invites visitors to consider the lives of royal women through the lenses of resistance, heritage and identity, pairing historical objects with contemporary responses," she says. And as exhibition historian Sinha states, 2026 marks the 150th birthday of Princess Sophia and hopes it offers "an opportunity to centre powerful women in this chapter of our shared history".

The Last Princesses of Punjab excels as a royal narrative of diasporic defiance. It frames the sisters not as victims of the British Raj, but as uneasy inheritors who transformed their displacement into a tapestry of public and private rebellion. Their stories, unearthed a century later, mirror the postcolonial condition itself – identities layered and rewritten, loyalties divided by oceans and flags. Among the fragments of silk and silver, gold jewellery and pink walls, a more complex silhouette emerges, one of women who navigated the in-between by redefining the very concept of home.

The Last Princesses of Punjab is at Kensington Palace till November 8.

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